

5. EAT WHERE KIDS EAT FREE

It's pretty crazy how many restaurants offer "kids eat free" days. MyKidsEatFree.com is the best website to find up-to-date promotions in your area, but I would still call ahead to make sure they haven't discontinued the program.

You can also Google "where do kids eat free in [INSERT CLOSEST METRO AREA]" for a few different results. Read the fine print, though, as many of these hinge on a paying adult for each cheap, or free, kid's meal.

While other restaurants might not have a "kids eat free" offer, they do advertise discounts and kid-only specials. And when you have a family, no matter the size, it's no secret that eating out costs add up quickly. Take advantage of any kid-friendly opportunity available to give your wallet a break!

6. COLLECT OR REQUEST GIFT CARDS

It never hurts to ask for gift cards to favorite restaurants for Christmas, birthdays, and even Mother's Day gifts. I know I certainly don't mind! Who needs more clutter anyway, when you can take your family out for a yummy meal and experience togetherness instead? Just be sure to keep your gift cards organized so you don't forget to use them.

You can also buy gift cards for yourself during holiday promos. Every year around Christmastime, restaurants promote specials like, "Buy a \$25 gift card, get an extra \$5 free." Restaurant.com is another place that offers local discounts up to 80% off.

I'll admit, it's always nice to go out to eat on someone else's dime, but it comes with an extra responsibility in regards to tipping. Be sure to tip on the full amount of your meals, not the remaining balance on the restaurant receipt. It's the right thing to do for our hardworking waiters and waitresses!